

Nestlé's leading baby-food brands, promoted in low- and middle-income countries as healthy and key to supporting young children's development, contain high levels of added sugar. In Switzerland, where Nestlé is headquartered, such products are sold with no added sugar. These are the main findings of a new investigation by Public Eye and the International Baby Food Action Network (IBFAN), which shed light on Nestlé's hypocrisy and the deceptive marketing strategies deployed by the Swiss food giant.

Meagan Adonis was 23 when she became blind as a result of a serious health condition. That same year she found out that she was pregnant, and was worried about the challenges of being a blind mum. She has now found her motherhood feet, and recently gave birth to a second child. Based in Johannesburg, South Africa, the "blind goddess" – as she calls herself – now documents her life for more than 125,000 followers on social media and chronicles her daily routine with her new baby.

Last year, Meagan posted several videos on TikTok promoting Cerelac infant cereals for babies from six months of age. "As you can see, I have a very active baby", she explains in a video in December. "As a blind mum, feeding time is always an adventure! [...] Now let's go and prepare his favourite meal of the day. Little bodies need big support with Nestlé Cerelac being the perfect addition to our mealtime," she assures her audience in a cheerful tone – while omitting to mention that this maternal counsel comes as part of a paid partnership with Nestlé.

Thousands of kilometres away, in Guatemala, a father films his energetic little daughter. "There's no greater satisfaction than seeing a strong, healthy child", says Billy Saavedra, a reggaeton artist better known as Billy the Diamond. "That's why we prefer Nido 1+, which supports the development of her bones and muscles, as well as her immune system", he adds in a video promoting the brand's formulas for young children in March on his Instagram account, which has more than 550,000 followers.

The use of influencers, such as Meagan or Billy (and their children), is at the core of Nestlé's marketing strategy to boost sales of its baby foods. This approach, which has become increasingly important in many sectors, allows companies to reach a broad audience, building on a sense of identification and relatability. Coming from parents with similar experiences, advertising messages are regarded as benevolent advice that can be trusted.

A growing market

Fifty years after the "baby killers" infant formula scandal, Nestlé claims to have learned from the past and proclaims its "unwavering commitment" to the "responsible marketing" of breast-milk substitutes. The food giant is doing everything it can to present itself as the world leader in infant nutrition, meticulously targeting each stage in a child's first years of life. It currently controls 20 percent of the baby-food market, valued at nearly \$70 billion.

Cerelac and Nido are some of Nestlé's best-selling baby-food brands in low- and middle-income countries. According to exclusive data obtained from Euro-monitor, a market analysis firm specializing in the food industry, their sales value in this category was greater than \$2.5 billion in 2022.

In its own communications or via third parties, Nestlé promotes Cerelac and Nido as brands whose aim is to help children "live healthier lives". Fortified with vitamins, minerals and other micronutrients, these products

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